

The Witherspoon Institute

Thomistic Seminar

Wednesday, July 29

Individual Happiness

Afternoon Session

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Readings:

Aquinas and the Ethics of Happiness, *Ch. 2*

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The Heart of Happiness

Enjoying Good Activities

What every sort of individual happiness shares, according to Aquinas, is that each is constituted exclusively by engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities. So what fundamentally unifies the wildly different kinds of individual happiness that Aquinas identifies into a single account is this underlying engagement-in-a-genuinely-good-activity *plus* enjoyment structure. This is the heart of happiness in Aquinas, or so I will argue over the course of the next four chapters.

This Enjoying Good Activities reading of Aquinas is a version of Restrictive Perfectionism about happiness. On this reading, only a small subset of an agent's perfections constitutes their happiness. In particular, one's happiness in every case is constituted exclusively by one's *activities*, when those activities are both genuinely good in themselves and enjoyed.

Two initial clarifications are in order. First, as we will see in detail below, an activity in this sense has a variety of aspects and may itself be partially constituted by other things. For example, the activity of having a conversation with a friend is partially constituted by that friend. This feature of activities will help to explain how other perfective human goods – such as our friends – can come to partially constitute our happiness in certain cases while still respecting Aquinas's core idea that happiness is constituted exclusively by activities that are genuinely good and enjoyed. Second, as I was at pains to emphasize in Chapter 1, according to any version of Restrictive Perfectionism, including the Enjoying Good Activities reading, there are other perfections that are intrinsically good for human beings besides those that constitute one's happiness. Virtues, for example, are perfections and intrinsically good for human beings, according to Aquinas, although they do not even partially constitute one's happiness. As a result, Aquinas occupies an interesting conceptual space. Aquinas's perfectionistic theory of what is good in itself for you is not identical to his perfectionistic theory of happiness. In other words, in contemporary terminology, although Aquinas endorses a form of perfectionism about both,

Aquinas's theory of well-being is not identical to his theory of happiness. This is an intriguing combination of views, which I will discuss further in the Conclusion of this study.

This chapter serves as an introduction to Aquinas's account of the heart of happiness. I start by briefly setting out the very basics of the textual case in its favor. I will significantly add to that case in the three subsequent chapters. The main focus of this chapter, however, is getting clearer on what it means to say that happiness is constituted exclusively by enjoying genuinely good activities. In order to do so, it will be vital to get clearer on how precisely Aquinas thinks of *enjoyment* and *genuinely good activities*. This will allow us to recognize and understand this shared structure and its implications as we look at particular kinds of happiness. Although this chapter's main concern is explaining the Enjoying Good Activities reading of Aquinas's heart of happiness, it should also make clearer the interest and philosophical promise of this account of happiness. As a result, it should also become apparent why it is worth moving on to a careful examination of Aquinas's discussions of particular kinds of happiness, even for those who have little antecedent interest in Aquinas's views.

2.1 Beginning to Uncover the Heart of Happiness in Aquinas

Aquinas faces an initial decision point between two importantly different sorts of received theories about what happiness fundamentally is. He could either side with Boethius and hold that happiness is fundamentally a state.¹ Or he could side with Aristotle and hold that happiness is fundamentally an activity.² He sides with Aristotle:

When a thing has a proper activity, the good of the thing and what it is for the thing to be well consists in its activity... The reason is that the final good of each thing is its ultimate perfection. Form is its first perfection and activity is its second perfection... Accordingly, the final good of each thing must be found in its activity. If, then, a human being has some characteristic activity, their final good, which is happiness, must consist in this. Consequently, happiness is the proper activity of a human being.³

Ever conciliatory, however, Aquinas says that “in defining ‘[perfect] happiness,’ Boethius had in mind the general concept of [perfect] happiness”

¹ Boethius, *The Consolation of Philosophy*, Book 3, Prose 2.

² EN 1.7 1098a16–19. Cf. InETH lib.1 l.10.

³ InETH lib.1 l.10 n.2. In this connection, see Pasnau and Shields (2016), 206ff., and Dewan (2007), 32–57.

and, in keeping with that general concept, it is true that “a [perfectly] happy person is in a perfectly good state.”⁴ So Boethius isn’t wrong, exactly. It’s just that Aquinas thinks we can peer more deeply into what happiness is. On Aquinas’s view, this is precisely what Aristotle did. “Aristotle draws out the very essence of happiness, showing through what a human being is in this sort of state, namely, through a certain activity.”⁵ Aquinas embraces, then, the Aristotelian idea that, in every case, happiness is an activity (*operatio*).⁶

For Aquinas, activity (*operatio*) is a broad notion.⁷ Things that take place only internally count as activities, such as thinking, willing, and understanding. So too do things that involve not only internal elements, but also doing things out there in the world, such as horseback riding or sharing a meal. Finally, making things in the world, such as building a house, which – obviously, again – involves not only internal elements, counts as an activity for Aquinas.⁸ Activities, then, encompass virtually every sort of thing that we do.

Although Aquinas embraces the broadly Aristotelian idea that happiness is an activity, he is at odds with Aristotle inasmuch as he holds that happiness is *exclusively* a matter of engaging in the right sorts of activities. Now, Aristotle certainly thinks that engaging in the right sorts of activities is fundamental to happiness (*eudaimonia*). But Aristotle does not think that happiness is exclusively a matter of engaging in those activities. According to Aristotle, other things are relevant to whether a person is happy or not besides aspects of the activities they engage in. Consider two important examples. First, according to Aristotle, the length of a person’s life is relevant to whether they can be happy or not. In particular, Aristotle holds that a person whose life is cut notably short could never count as happy. In support of this claim, Aristotle says, “For one swallow does not make a spring, nor does one day; nor, similarly, does one day or a short time make us blessed and happy.”⁹ So even if a person has engaged in excellent activities before having their life cut significantly short, they

⁴ ST IaIIae q.3 a.2 ad 2. ⁵ ST IaIIae q.3 a.2 ad 2. Cf. InETH lib.1 l.10.

⁶ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.3 a.2; InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.2 qc.2 s.c.1; InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.2 qc.4 s.c.1; and QQ8 q.9 a.1 co. Treating happiness as an activity was not unique to Aristotle (see Annas (1995), 36–37, 45). On the Aristotelian background of Aquinas’s view and Aquinas’s understanding of Aristotle’s view, see, e.g., Huber (1893); Kenny (1999); Adams (1991); Kleber (1988), chapter 3; and Müller (2013).

⁷ See, e.g., InETH lib.1 l.1 n.13.

⁸ Regarded merely as kinds of activities, Aquinas thinks that internal activities are more noble than external activities (see, e.g., InETH lib.1 l.1 n.13; ST IaIIae q.3 a.2 ad 3; Cf. InETH lib.1 l.12 n.6).

⁹ EN 1.7 1098a19–21. See also, e.g., EN 1.10 1101a15–17.

would not count as happy for Aristotle. Second, according to Aristotle, even if a person has lived a notably long life and engaged in the right sorts of activities throughout, their life being brought to a calamitous end undercuts the possibility of their having been happy. Aristotle uses Priam, Troy's king at the time of its destruction, as an example of just such a case.¹⁰ In this respect too something besides aspects of the activities one engages in are treated as relevant to whether or not a person can be happy, namely, the sorts of tragic events that befall one, even those that are outside one's control.

The deep reason it seems natural to Aristotle to treat other things besides aspects of the activities one engages in as relevant to happiness has to do with a widely held ancient idea, noted in the Introduction – namely, the idea that whatever happiness (*eudaimonia*) is, it must characterize *a life as a whole*. There are various ways this sort of whole-life concept of happiness might be developed. But, regardless, if you think that happiness must characterize a life as a whole, it seems quite reasonable to think that, for example the length of a life and the sorts of calamities that occur during a person's life are relevant to whether a person counts as happy, even if one thinks that a person's activities are the most important aspect of their happiness. After all, one might think that a life cut very short or a life marked by terrible tragedy is just not the sort of life that can meet the standard requisite for happiness.

Crucially, as I will explain in greater detail in Chapter 4, Aquinas rejects the idea that happiness must characterize a life as a whole. Instead, he treats happiness as primarily episodic – that is, as something that primarily characterizes episodes in a life or parts of a life. This major conceptual shift away from the ancient idea is intimately connected to Aquinas's treating happiness as *exclusively* a matter of engaging in the right sorts of activities. The basic line of thought is that, if happiness is exclusively an activity and activities are episodic, then so too happiness is episodic. And so a person can be happy during an episode of a life so long as their activity or activities are of the right kind. This major conceptual shift leads Aquinas to reject Aristotle's claim that a person must live a relatively long time in order to count as happy. He says this position “does not seem to be reasonable.”¹¹ So too it leads Aquinas to deny the claim that a person's life being brought to a calamitous end undercuts the possibility of their

¹⁰ EN 1.9 1100a5–9 and EN 1.10 1100b34–1101a7–8.

¹¹ InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.1 qc.4 co. Later in InETH, Aquinas minimizes the distance between Aristotle's view and his own view (see InETH lib.10 l.11 n.7).

having ever been happy.¹² So long as one engages in the right sort of activity, one is happy to some extent.¹³ So, as I understand him, Aquinas pulls out one strand of Aristotle's account of happiness – that happiness is an activity – develops it relentlessly, and thereby radically transforms Aristotle.

As we've already seen, as Aquinas thinks of it, there are two most basic kinds of happiness: perfect happiness and imperfect happiness. Both are exclusively a matter of engaging in the right sort of activity. In the case of perfect happiness, Aquinas tells us that perfect happiness "is the best activity of a human being" and the "maximally pleasurable" one.¹⁴ In the case of imperfect happiness of whatever kind, he repeatedly tells us that "imperfect happiness . . . consists in virtuous activity."¹⁵ So, again, happiness of whatever kind consists exclusively in the right sort of activity.

Recall that the heart of happiness, as I'm thinking of it, captures what makes every kind of happiness that Aquinas identifies relevantly similar. What is left to do in uncovering the heart of happiness, then, is to determine what Aquinas believes is relevantly shared by the best and most enjoyable activity, on the one hand, and all virtuous activities, on the other.

For those conversant with Aquinas's understanding of virtuous activity, the answer should jump off the page. By their very nature, according to Aquinas, virtuous activities are always genuinely good and they are always enjoyed.¹⁶ So imperfect happiness always involves engaging in and enjoying a genuinely good activity. This is true whether the imperfect happiness in question is natural or graced, contemplative or active. Perfect happiness, as the best and most enjoyable activity, also necessarily involves engaging in and enjoying a genuinely good activity. And so we have arrived at what I take to be the heart of happiness in Aquinas: Happiness in every case is constituted by nothing more and nothing less than an activity with a certain structure, namely, an activity that is genuinely good and enjoyed.

This is, of course, much too brief to serve as anything like a complete defense of this reading of Aquinas. The full defense comes over the course of the next three chapters. For now, however, I will assume that I have correctly identified the heart of happiness in Aquinas and turn to

¹² Aristotle's view: EN 1.9 1100a5–9 and EN 1.10 1100b34–1101a7–8. Aquinas's view: InETH lib.1 l.15 n.2–3; InETH lib.1 l.16 n.13; ST IaIIae q.5 a.4 co.

¹³ ST IaIIae q.5 a.4 co. ¹⁴ ST IaIIae q.3 a.5 co.

¹⁵ ST IaIIae q.4 a.7 co. See also, e.g., ST IaIIae q.4 a.6 co.; ST IaIIae q.5 a.5 co.; and ST IaIIae q.5 a.6 co. (Cf. InETH lib.1 l.10 n.11.)

¹⁶ See Chapters 4 and 8 on why.

explaining what this view actually amounts to, given Aquinas's understanding of enjoyment, on the one hand, and of genuinely good activities, on the other.

2.2 Enjoyment and Happiness

If I'm right, according to Aquinas, a person's happiness is partially constituted by their enjoyment of their activity. That is the reason a person can't be happy without enjoying what they are doing. As a result, Aquinas holds, "Delight belongs to the nature (*rationem*) of happiness."¹⁷ This proposal shouldn't sound particularly startling. There is a long tradition, running up to the present day, that treats enjoyment or pleasure as a crucial or even the sole constituent of happiness.¹⁸ And one might think that tradition has at least something right. It is natural to suppose that happy people enjoy or take pleasure or in some way are attracted to their lives and the things in them. People who have lots of things ordinarily sought, such as wealth, health, and people who care about them, but who are unmoved by these things, seem less worthy of envy than pity. So a happy life is an (at least somewhat) attractive life to the person living it. This was a bedrock belief about happiness in antiquity, which Aquinas embraces, going so far as to make the spurious etymological claim that "the Greek word for happiness is taken from [the word for] enjoyment."¹⁹

In principle, Aquinas had at his disposal a number of possible ways to capture this sort of attractiveness constraint on happiness.²⁰ He could have appealed, for example, to desire-satisfaction, bodily pleasure, or enjoyment. He chose enjoyment, understood as non-bodily pleasure or non-bodily delight. In this section, I explain in some detail how Aquinas understands bodily pleasure, enjoyment, desire-satisfaction, and the relationships between them.²¹ I also offer an explanation as to why Aquinas treated enjoyment as fundamentally and essentially relevant to happiness, rather than bodily pleasure or desire-satisfaction.

¹⁷ ST IIaIIae q.148 a.5 co.

¹⁸ Aquinas knew, e.g., about Epicurus (see ST IIaIIae q.34 a.2 co. and InETH lib.10 l.4 n.6).

¹⁹ InSENT lib. 4 d.49 q.1 a.1 qc.2 arg.2 (not denied). As a bedrock claim, see, e.g., Annas (1995), 330.

²⁰ Cf. Railton (2003), 47, and the resonance constraint.

²¹ Aquinas's understanding of the relation between *delectatio* and *gaudium* seems to have changed – compare, e.g., InSENT, lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.1 qc.4 and ST IIaIIae q.31, especially a.3–5. In what follows, I rely predominately on the later treatment in the ST, but I take it nothing significant changed concerning his account of happiness as a result of this terminological change.

For Aquinas on pleasure, see, e.g., White (2013) and Miner (2009), chapter 7.

Enjoyment (*gaudium*) and bodily pleasure (*voluptas*) are the two main kinds of pleasure or delight (*delectatio*) that Aquinas identifies.²² He thinks that the differences between them track a deeper fact about human beings, namely, that we have two different appetitive faculties responsible for two different sorts of desires.²³ We should postulate these faculties, Aquinas thinks, in order to explain internal conflicts between what we want *qua* animal and *qua* rational, so to speak.²⁴ Distinguishing between these two faculties can help to explain the internal conflict of, for example, a patient who sees tasty food while fasting for a colonoscopy: *Qua* animal, when the patient sees the food, they very much want to eat it, but, *qua* rational, the patient also very much wants to refrain from eating it so the colonoscopy can be conducted successfully. Aquinas calls the source of desires of the first kind the “sensory appetite” because it is primarily responsive to what is presented to it by the senses, and he calls the source of desires of the second kind the “rational appetite” (or “the will”) because it is responsive to what is presented to it by reason (*ratio*) as good or bad.²⁵

Now, as Aquinas thinks of them, desire and pleasure are importantly connected. Desire and pleasure are both the product of the very same underlying force in an appetitive faculty, namely, the force of its loving or being drawn to something in itself.²⁶ He says, even after getting what you want, “the movement of the appetitive part does not cease, which just as before was desiring what was not had, so later delights in what is had.”²⁷ So desire results from an appetitive faculty’s loving or being drawn to something that is not yet attained, whereas pleasure results from an appetitive faculty’s loving or being drawn to something that has been attained. So, what changes when the sensory appetite or rational appetite goes from desiring something to taking pleasure in it has nothing to do with those appetites themselves. What explains the change from desire to pleasure is the change from not having the relevant thing to having it.²⁸ If ‘desire’ is taken loosely, then, pleasure can be thought of as continuing to desire something that you now have.

²² See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.30 a.1 co. On bodily pleasure, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.31 a.1 co.; for enjoyment (*gaudium*) as “species” of delight, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.31 a.3 co.

²³ ST IaIIae q.23 a.1; ST IaIIae q.56 a.4; ST IaIIae q.50 a.3; ST Ia q.82; ST IaIIae q.56 a.4; ST IaIIae q.74 a.3; ST IaIIae q.82; ST IaIIae q.17 a.7; ST IaIIae q.56 a.4; InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.1 qc.1 co.; InSENT, lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.1 qc.2 co. For Aquinas on desire, see Stancato (2011).

²⁴ See, e.g., ST Ia a.3 ad 2 and ST IaIIae q.77; cf. InETH lib.1 l.20 n.7.

²⁵ For sense, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.31 a.1 co. For reason, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.8 a.1; ST IaIIae q.9 a.1; ST IaIIae q.31 a.4 co.; ST IaIIae q.19 a.3 co.

²⁶ ST IaIIae q.2 a.7 ad 1. ST IaIIae q.31 a.1 ad 2. ²⁷ ST IaIIae q.31 a.1 ad 2.

²⁸ See, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.1 qc.2 co.; ST IaIIae q.31 a.1 ad 2.

So, in every case, pleasure is a matter of continuing to love or desire or be drawn to something that you have already attained that at least appears either to reason or to sense to be a fitting good in itself – fitting, that is, to one's nature as a rational animal.²⁹ The differences between bodily pleasure and enjoyment fundamentally track the differences between the sensory appetite, which, according to Aquinas, is a bodily faculty, and the rational appetite, which is purely a faculty of the soul.³⁰ Since the sensory appetite is tied up with the body and the bodily senses, the kind of pleasure associated with the sensory appetite is, unsurprisingly, bodily pleasure. The body's role in this sort of pleasure is essential because, in every case, bodily pleasure involves pleasant bodily sensations resulting from "some bodily change," generally, running back through at least one of the five senses.³¹ So one can, in principle, take bodily pleasure in any physical representation of a fitting good in itself that is traced back to the five senses.³² Sexual pleasure and gustatory pleasure are the paradigm cases of bodily pleasure for Aquinas.³³

Enjoyment, on the other hand, is the kind of pleasure associated with the rational appetite or will.³⁴ Whereas the sensory appetite characteristically takes pleasure in what is presented to it through the senses, the rational appetite can take pleasure in whatever reason presents to it as a fitting good in itself.³⁵ As a result, the range of things that one can enjoy is immense. Anything that can be thought of as a fitting good in itself can, in principle, be enjoyed. So we can enjoy everything from completing a math problem

²⁹ Drawn from: ST IaIIae q.31 a.1 co. and ad 2.; ST IaIIae q.31 a.5 co.; ST IaIIae q.31 a.7 co.; ST IaIIae q.32 a.1 co.; ST IaIIae q.32 a.1 ad 1; InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.5 qc.1 co. What I've said is true both of pleasure without qualification (*simpliciter*) and pleasure in a certain respect (*secundum quid*) because pleasure without qualification is only had in things that are good without qualification and not merely apparently good, whereas pleasure in a certain respect can be had in something that is not good without qualification (ST IaIIae q.34 a.2 co.). I say "fitting to one's nature" because Aquinas thinks we can distinguish between goods fitting to one's human nature and fitting to one's own particular nature, where that includes, e.g., facts about one's unique bodily constitution (see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.34 a.2 co.).

³⁰ On these faculties, see, e.g., ST Ia q.80–82.

³¹ ST IaIIae q.31 a.4 co. See also, e.g., InSENT, lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.1 qc.1 co.; ST q.31 a.1 co. The exception is when bodily pleasure results from what Aquinas describes metaphorically as the overflow of pleasure from the rational appetite to the sensory appetite. See, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.5 qc.1 co.; ST IaIIae q.24 a.3 ad 1; ST IaIIae q.17 a.7; ST IaIIae q.59 a.5 co.; ST IaIIae q.38 a.4 ad 3; ST IaIIae q.31 a.5 co. On the bodily affections or passions, see, e.g., King (1999) and (2012) and Miner (2009).

³² Memories and hope can also result in bodily pleasure – see ST IaIIae q.32 a.3.

³³ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.31 a.6 co. ³⁴ ST IaIIae q.31 a.4 co.

³⁵ On rational appetite's dependence on reason for its object, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.9 a.1. That rational appetite takes pleasure in what is presented to it by reason, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.31 a.4 co. That anything presented as good can be an object of the will's activity, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.25 a.2 co.

to art to helping other people to watching sports to bodily pleasures to justice.³⁶ So too we can enjoy memories of things past and the hope of things to come.³⁷ Now, unlike bodily pleasure, enjoyment in itself does not involve any associated changes in one's bodily sensations; Aquinas calls it "a simple movement of the will" – it is simply a matter of being drawn at the level of reason to what, in some sense, one already has.³⁸ As a result, one could, in principle, enjoy something while not taking in any sensory information, as Aquinas believes is actually the case with separated souls in heaven.³⁹ It is not a feeling, then, but a kind of pro-attitude toward something that one has attained in some sense, whether in memory, in hope, or in fact.⁴⁰

There are a number of reasons that Aquinas believes that enjoyment is a better candidate than bodily pleasure for the sort of affective response fundamentally and essentially connected to happiness.⁴¹ Perhaps the most important is that it seems possible, at least in principle, for someone not feeling pleasant bodily sensations to be happy. Aquinas thinks that this is actually the case with some human souls separated from bodies.⁴² But we might also think it is clear that, for example, someone who has taken serious sensation-numbing medicine that makes feeling any sensations at all impossible may be happy as they talk with loved ones, while recovering after a successful surgery. On the other hand, it is not clear that it is possible for someone not enjoying anything to be happy, even if they were experiencing bodily pleasure. Of course, the very possibility of such a thing requires that bodily pleasure and enjoyment be separable, which they seem to be, since, as Aquinas notes, although we generally enjoy bodily pleasures, one need not enjoy every bodily pleasure that one experiences.⁴³ So, for example, consider a pampered trust funder suffering from ennui, who eats high quality food, but does not enjoy it. In other words, they eat, but, at the level of reason, they are not pleased with what they are eating; they do not love what they are doing. Despite experiencing bodily pleasure, it

³⁶ On will's enjoying food, see, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.1 qc.4 co. ³⁷ ST IaIIae q.32 a.3.

³⁸ ST IaIIae q.31 a.4 co. ³⁹ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.4 a.5.

⁴⁰ ST IaIIae q.32 a.3. Aquinas's distinction between bodily pleasure and enjoyment is roughly the distinction made today between physical pleasure and attitudinal pleasure – see, e.g., Feldman (2006) and (2012).

⁴¹ Others include (1) nonhuman animals are incapable of being happy and they experience bodily pleasures, but not enjoyment, since they lack *rational* appetites (SCG lib.3 c.27 n.4); and (2) intellectual pleasures are better than bodily pleasures (InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.5 qc.1 co. and ST IaIIae q.31 a.5).

⁴² See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.4 a.5. And with angels (no body: ST Ia q.50 a.1; happy: ST Ia q.62) and God (no body: ST Ia q.3 a.1; happy: ST Ia q.26).

⁴³ On separability, see ST IaIIae q.31 a.3 co. On enjoying bodily sensations, see ST IaIIae q.31 a.4 co.

does not seem that they are happy as they eat because, again, their activity is devoid of enjoyment – this and other good things in their life fail to be attractive to them at the level of reason. And so, to sum up, given that happiness apart from bodily pleasure seems possible and happiness apart from enjoyment doesn't seem possible, Aquinas is right to think that enjoyment is a better candidate than bodily pleasure for the sort of affective response fundamentally and essentially connected to happiness.

Aquinas also gives us reason to think he's right to treat enjoyment as a better candidate for being a constitutive element of happiness than desire-satisfaction. This is so even when we set aside the satisfaction of desires issuing from the sensory appetite; we ought to do so since we have already seen that enjoyment is a better candidate than the satisfaction of the desires of the sensory appetite even in the best-case scenario – that is, when those desires are satisfied and one goes on being drawn to the thing in question, resulting in bodily pleasure. Even when focusing just on the satisfaction of reason-dependent desires – by which I mean, desires issuing from the rational appetite or will in response to what is presented to it by reason – it will turn out that enjoyment is still a better candidate when it comes to the sort of affective response fundamentally and essentially connected to happiness.

This is so because, although every enjoyment involves the sort of attractiveness we'd expect from happiness, not every satisfaction of a reason-dependent desire involves that sort of attractiveness. After all, sometimes we have reason-dependent desires for things that we find desirable only as means to some end. In other words, sometimes we don't conceive of the things we desire as ends in themselves or as good in themselves, but only as good and desirable insofar as they connect up with something else that we do conceive of as an end in itself or good in itself, at least in part.⁴⁴ For example, our patient's reason-dependent desire to fast before their colonoscopy is of that kind. The patient desires to fast only because fasting is the means to their having a successful colonoscopy and thereby to their making well-informed decisions moving forward in their pursuit of health, which they desire, at least in part, for its own sake. As Aquinas thinks of it, we can only enjoy things that we conceive of as being, at least in part, ends in themselves or fitting goods in themselves.⁴⁵ So every enjoyment involves our loving or being drawn to the thing *in itself* that we're enjoying. As a result, whenever we satisfy a reason-dependent

⁴⁴ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.70 a.1 ad 2; InETH lib.1 l.9 n.7; and InETH lib.10 l.9 n.4–5.

⁴⁵ ST IaIIae q.70 a.1 ad 2.

desire for a mere means, that desire-satisfaction does not involve enjoyment. And now we can see why, although enjoyment does, every satisfaction of a reason-dependent desire does not involve the sort of attractiveness we'd expect from happiness. Think of the patient as they continue to fast on the morning of their colonoscopy, having refrained from eating the entirety of the previous day. Every moment they keep the fast, they are satisfying their reason-dependent desire to fast. But they can hardly wait until they can give up that desire and its satisfaction. They would give up that desire's satisfaction in an instant, if there were some other way to reach their goal. In such a state, it seems odd to think that the very satisfaction of this desire, which they so badly wish they didn't have to be satisfying, contributes to their being happy as they wait for the procedure. Satisfying that reason-dependent desire just doesn't involve the sort of attractiveness we'd expect from something that even partially constitutes our happiness. I take it that that is an important part of the reason "happiness is limited to those activities which are choiceworthy in themselves, and not those which are choiceworthy [only] because of something further."⁴⁶ So it seems that there are good reasons that Aquinas treats enjoyment as fundamentally and essentially connected to happiness, rather than bodily pleasure or desire-satisfaction.⁴⁷

So, according to Aquinas, if a person is happy, they are loving or desiring or being drawn to something presented to their rational appetite by reason as a fitting good in itself and as attained.⁴⁸ In other words, if a person is happy, then they're enjoying something they think of as good. And, unsurprisingly, given that enjoyment is a constituent of happiness, all else being equal, the more they enjoy the fitting good or goods in question, the happier they are, according to Aquinas.⁴⁹ There is no great mystery in explaining degrees of enjoyment, on Aquinas's view. The more you love or are drawn to something you have attained, the more you enjoy it.⁵⁰

⁴⁶ InETH lib.10 l.9 n.5.

⁴⁷ Still, Aquinas thinks it is good when, responsive to rationally desiring something good, your sensory appetite issues in appropriate bodily pleasure (see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.24 a.3). One might restrict relevant desire-satisfactions to those connected to *intrinsic desires* (or desires for things in themselves) issuing from the rational appetite that involve the simultaneity of the desire and its satisfaction; Heathwood (2005) suggests something along these lines. But then we've arrived at what Aquinas means by '*gaudium*' and the issue becomes merely terminological.

⁴⁸ Drawn from a series of texts: ST IaIIae q.31 a.1 ad 2.; ST IaIIae q.31 a.5 co.; ST IaIIae q.32 a.1 co.; and ST IaIIae q.32 a.1 ad 1.

⁴⁹ Clear in the case of perfect happiness – see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.5 a.2 co. Also true in the case of imperfect happiness (see, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.1 qc.3 s.c.3.), but it is more complicated (see Chapter 4).

⁵⁰ InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.5 qc.1 co.; ST IaIIae q.32 a.8 co.; ST IaIIae q.31 a.6 co.

And so, all else being equal, the more you love or are drawn to the fitting good or goods in question, the happier you are.

2.3 Genuinely Good Activities and Happiness

By now it should also be clear that, according to Aquinas, enjoyment is always enjoyment *of something*. There is no such thing as enjoyment detached from what is enjoyed. As a result, enjoyment is always dependent on a further activity accompanying the enjoyment of the will.⁵¹ This is so because, at the very least, enjoying something always requires thinking about that something you're enjoying, and thinking is itself an activity.⁵² Moreover, attaining something to enjoy often requires a wider sort of activity.⁵³ For example, enjoying the taste of a peach requires biting into it, and enjoying a conversation with friends requires listening, speaking, and so on. So it's no surprise that, according to Aquinas, a person can't be happy without doing something.⁵⁴ But Aquinas goes further than that. He treats this further activity that is enjoyed not merely as a necessary condition for being happy, but as what it most fundamentally is.⁵⁵ The activity beyond enjoyment, then, is more fundamental in happiness than enjoyment itself, although both are partially constitutive of happiness.⁵⁶ And not just any enjoyable activity will do. If one is to be happy, the further activity one enjoys must be *genuinely good* and, indeed, one must enjoy it because of its genuine goodness. Even for one's enjoyment to be counted as something good in the first place, it must be taken in a genuinely good activity.⁵⁷ In the end, as a result of all of this, according to Aquinas, only good people can be happy.

All of this may sound strange to modern ears. Most of us would be perfectly willing to entertain the possibility, for example, that Hitler enjoyed plotting the Holocaust and that, as a result, he was happy while doing so. Obviously, that activity was not genuinely good. So it seems

⁵¹ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.32 a.1; InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.2 ad 1; and InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.2 co.

⁵² See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.32 a.1 co. and ad 1; ST IaIIae q.32 a.5 co.; InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.3 qc.2 co.; InSENT l.4 d.49 q.3 a.5 qc.1 co.

⁵³ ST IaIIae q.32 a.1.

⁵⁴ For perfect happiness, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.3 a.2. For natural imperfect happiness, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.4 a.7; ST IaIIae q.5 a.5 co.; ST IaIIae q.5 a.6 co. For graced imperfect happiness, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.69 a.1 co.

⁵⁵ ST IaIIae q.3 a.2 ad 2. See also, e.g., CT lib.1 c.107; QQ. VIII q.9 a.1 co. (Cf. SLE lib.10 l.6 n.17.)

⁵⁶ See Chapter 3.

⁵⁷ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.34 a.1–2 and InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.4 qc.1 co. (Cf. SLE lib.10 l.4, l.7–8.)

possible for a person to be happy while enjoying downright bad activities, not only genuinely good ones.

This would have scandalized many ancient Greek philosophers. There was widespread agreement that, whatever happiness was, it was not only attractive, but also consisted “in what matters most, what is most valuable.”⁵⁸ Among the ancients, then, there was a kind of genuine value or genuine goodness constraint on happiness in addition to an attractiveness constraint. Aquinas accepts these features of the ancient tradition and so he accepts this way of thinking about these two general features of happiness. As a result, he too must find a place for the genuine goodness of happiness in his account.

Now, as we began to see in Chapter 1, when it comes to genuine value or genuine goodness, Aquinas has a story to tell about everything from individuals of whatever kind to activities of whatever kind. As an entirely general matter, on a metaphysical level, Aquinas believes, roughly (and perhaps mysteriously to the average modern reader), that things and activities are genuinely good to the extent to which they have being.⁵⁹ When it comes to things, the basic idea is that there are some properties that things of a particular kind should have. For example, among many other things, human beings should have two hands, be able to digest food, engage in abstract reasoning, and be courageous. A human being is good to the extent to which they have these and similarly fitting properties; the most important such fitting properties concern making our rational appetites or wills good.⁶⁰ When it comes to activities, the basic idea is the same: There are some properties that the activities of particular kinds of things should have.⁶¹ For example, human activities should be done in accord with right reason, which – on the basis of grasping how, in fact, things ought to be ordered and done – involves doing the right sort of thing, for the right reasons, at the right time and place, and so on.⁶² A human activity is good to the extent to which it is done in accord with right reason in these various respects, as I explain in more detail below.⁶³

⁵⁸ Annas (1995), 365.

⁵⁹ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.18 a.1 co and ST Ia q.5. I say “roughly” because some think this claim draws an analogy between ontological goodness and moral goodness (see, e.g., Bradley (1997), 263). On how Aquinas understands goodness in general and the human case, see, e.g., Aertsen (1999); Stump (2005), chapter 2; Stump and Kretzmann (2018); and Gallagher (2018).

⁶⁰ For the general claim, see, e.g., ST Ia q.5 a.1 ad 1. For the will claim, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.56 a.3 and ST Ia q.5 a.4 ad 3. On the centrality of the will in moral evaluation, see, e.g., Gallagher (2018).

⁶¹ ST IaIIae q.18 a.1 co.

⁶² ST IaIIae q.18 a.5 co. See Bourke (1974) and (1975); Yartz (1975); and Bowlin (1999), chapter 3.

⁶³ Chapter 7 also reflects on what accords with right reason inasmuch as the moral law articulates what right reason demands.

What is more, according to Aquinas, there is also an explanation for right reason's playing this role in the case of human activities. He says, "In human actions, good and bad are predicated in relation to reason because, as Dionysius says (Div. Nom. iv), 'the good of a human being is to be in accord with reason,' and bad 'what is contrary to reason.' For that is good for a thing which is fitting in accord with its form and bad which is contrary to the order of its form."⁶⁴ And, indeed, not only when it comes to activities, but also to external goods and goods of the body, what matters is fittingness to reason: "external and bodily goods are good for a human being inasmuch as they promote the good of reason, but when they impede the good of reason, they are turned into bad things."⁶⁵ So, ultimately, according to Aquinas, the reason that something is good for a human being, whether a character trait, an external good, a good of the body, or an activity, is that it is fitting for rational and social animals like us.⁶⁶ This, again, is Aquinas's perfectionism about *goods in general*.

Given Aquinas's acceptance of a genuine goodness constraint on happiness and this way of understanding goodness, it should come as no surprise that Aquinas limits the sorts of activities that can, in principle, involve happiness to those that are genuinely good, including genuinely *morally* good.⁶⁷ So too, as we saw in Chapter 1, it should come as no surprise that Aquinas is sure that bad people can't be happy.⁶⁸ And so, from the perspective afforded by his theory, at least, there is good reason to deny that Hitler was happy while planning the Holocaust.

Still, one might think that this older approach to happiness is entirely foreign to our way of thinking today. I am not convinced that it is.⁶⁹ There is, of course, one sense of the English term 'happy' in which saying "Hitler

⁶⁴ ST IaIIae q.18 a.5 co. See also, e.g., QDVir q.1 a.12 co. and InETH lib.2 l.2. According to Aquinas, all things are governed rationally by God and do well insofar as they follow God's rational plan for their development. Following a rational plan is not good for us *just because* we have a rational nature. Following a rational plan is good for everything. It's just that we can knowingly follow that plan, which is why – according to Aquinas – we were given a law cognitively as opposed to merely inclinationally – see, e.g., SCG lib.3 c.114, 129. On this point, see Porter (1999), 85ff.

⁶⁵ SCG lib.3 c.141 n.6. See also, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.1 qc.1 s.c.3 and SCG lib.3 cap.133 n.1.
⁶⁶ Aquinas thinks that we can push the explanation back still further to God's eternal law (see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.19 a.4 co. and ST IaIIae q.21 a.1). Aquinas recognizes and addresses other connected issues. For example, he recognizes that something might be fitting for this particular person but not another particular person (e.g., it might be fitting for a person with cancer to do chemotherapy but not a healthy person). So he distinguishes between what is good *simpliciter* for a human being and what is good in a particular case, due to an unnatural state – see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.34 a.2 co.

⁶⁷ On why all genuinely good activities must be genuinely morally good, see, e.g., Gallagher (2018).

⁶⁸ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.2 a.4 co. as well as, e.g., ST IaIIae q.4 a.6 co. and a.7 co.; ST IaIIae q.5 a.5 co. and a.6 co.

⁶⁹ With, e.g., Foot (2001), chapter 6.

was happy” is entirely unstrained. In particular, this is unstrained when one has the purely descriptive sense of the term in mind. In that sense, being happy has solely to do with something connected to a positive psychological state, which, depending on the psychologist or philosopher, may be cashed out in terms of pleasure, enjoyment, mood, desire-satisfaction, or some combination of these.⁷⁰ However, at least something of the more ancient approach still peaks through in an evaluative sense of the term ‘happy.’ That second sense can be seen, for example, when people say things like “I really thought I was happy, but I see now that I wasn’t.” Such a person isn’t saying, “I really thought that my mental life was characterized by pleasure and good moods, but I see now that it wasn’t.” I take it, at least ordinarily, this is a claim about previously thinking that one’s pleasant pattern of life was truly good for one but later becoming convinced that it wasn’t.⁷¹ So I think we should at least provisionally take Aquinas’s account as an account of what happiness amounts to in something roughly like this second sense.⁷² And even if this use of ‘happy’ were to fade from English usage, happiness understood with roughly the general characteristics that Aquinas and the ancients ascribe to it seems worth considering, as both a historical and a philosophical matter. After all, it seems at least possible that happiness so understood may be a helpful concept as we reflect on ethical questions. But in order to determine how valuable it might be, we need to delve into the thick of the theory.

Still, one might wonder if thinking of happiness as a matter of engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities is sufficient to block the possibility of someone truly bad being happy. We might think that it’s quite obvious that even very bad people, at least sometimes, engage in genuinely good activities. For example, all but the most greedy at least sometimes provide some small measure of material support for others, which is surely a good thing to do. Indeed, it is hard to imagine someone so scrupulously villainous that they never do anything good.⁷³

From the very fact, then, that bad people cannot engage in genuinely good activities, according to Aquinas, it should immediately be clear that

⁷⁰ For an introduction to various options, see, e.g., Feldman (2012) and Haybron (2020).

⁷¹ Perhaps someone might utter this sentence to express the following: “I thought that I had sufficiently high positive affect to count as happy before, but I see now that I didn’t cross the relevant threshold.” What matters for present purposes, however, is that there is at least one natural way to take the sentence in which ‘happy’ involves more than some positive psychological state, and it seems to me that there is such a way.

⁷² For this distinction, see, e.g., Haybron (2020). As should be clear, I do not think happiness in Aquinas’s evaluative sense includes everything that is good in itself for a human being.

⁷³ A point Aquinas makes, e.g., at ST IIaIIae q.58 a.1 ad 3.

Aquinas's standard for genuine goodness in activity is demanding.⁷⁴ As Aquinas thinks of it, "An action is not good absolutely, unless it is good in every way" (*nisi omnes bonitates concurrant*).⁷⁵ And there are many ways that an activity can be good or bad; that is, there are many ways human activities can accord or fail to accord with right reason.⁷⁶

What is done can be good or bad.⁷⁷ In other words, an activity can be bad because the immediate course of action being pursued is bad – that is, contrary to right reason.⁷⁸ For example, the activity of "taking what belongs to another" is not genuinely good because doing so is a bad immediate course of action, full stop.⁷⁹ A genuinely good activity, then, will involve undertaking not a bad immediate course of action, but either a good one (e.g., helping the poor) or a neutral one (e.g., picking up a straw).⁸⁰

An activity can also be bad as a result of *why* it is done. Your aims or ends in doing it matter to its goodness – that is, whether your aims in engaging in the activity accord with right reason plays a role in determining whether the activity is good or bad.⁸¹ For example, if someone helps an elderly man carry his groceries into his apartment in order to steal something, that activity is not genuinely good. Nor, more subtly, would an activity be good if, for example, you undertook it just because you wanted to be praised.⁸² A genuinely good activity, then, must be done with good aims or for good reasons. And, in particular, in order for an activity to be genuinely good, it must be undertaken (at least in part) *because* it is the good and right thing to do.⁸³ Furthermore, every genuinely good activity must aim at some level at the common good of one's community. In particular, at the very least, according to Aquinas, one must act in ways that are consistent with the good of one's earthly community.⁸⁴ And, at

⁷⁴ To deeply understand this point, see ST IaIIae q.6–21.

⁷⁵ ST IaIIae q.18 a.4 ad 3. See also, e.g., ST IaIIae q.20 a.2 co.

⁷⁶ For book-length treatments of Aquinas's account of goodness, see, e.g., Jensen (2010); Pilsner (2006); and McCluskey (2016). For briefer treatments, see, e.g., Dewan (2007), 444–477; Westberg (2002); DeYoung, McCluskey, and Van Dyke (2009), chapter 5; Elders (2005), chapter 3; McNerny (1992), chapter 4, and (1997), chapter 5; and, for treatments that discuss Aquinas's views in relation to other medieval views, see, e.g., Hoffmann (2003) and Osborne (2014), chapters 4 and 5.

⁷⁷ On this idea, see also Flannery (2003).

⁷⁸ ST IaIIae q.18 a.2 and a.5. See also, e.g., ST IaIIae q.20 a.1.

⁷⁹ ST IaIIae q.18 a.2 co. and ST IaIIae q.18 a.5 ad 2. ⁸⁰ ST IaIIae q.18 a.8 co.

⁸¹ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.18 a.4.; ST IaIIae q.18 a.6; ST IaIIae q.18 a.9 co. Cf. SCG lib.3 c.138 n.5, n.7.

⁸² ST IaIIae q.19 a.7 ad 2.

⁸³ See ST IaIIae q.100 a.9 co.; ST IIaIIae q.58 a.1 co.; and InETH lib.2 l.4 n.4. (Cf. EN 2.4 1105a31–35.)

⁸⁴ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.90 a.2; ST IaIIae q.90 a.4 co.; ST IaIIae q.21 a.2 ad 2.

best, one might act for the sake of friendship with God and the community of the Kingdom of God.⁸⁵ In any case, in order to engage in a genuinely good activity, one must see oneself as part of one's community and act accordingly.⁸⁶

Broadly speaking, *how* the activity is done can also result in an activity's being bad – that is, how an activity is done can be contrary to right reason.⁸⁷ An activity is bad if it is not done as it should be done, when it should be done, where it should be done, and so on.⁸⁸ So, for example, lovingly confronting a friend, who has been behaving badly toward you, is a good thing to do. However, if you were to confront that friend, for example, in earshot of their coworkers, the otherwise good activity would be spoiled by the circumstances in which it is undertaken. A genuinely good activity, then, will always be undertaken as it should be, when it should be, where it should be, and so on.⁸⁹

Finally, an activity that follows a neutral or good immediate course of action, undertaken as it should be, and undertaken with the right sorts of good aims in view may fail to be genuinely good for another reason. This is so because, although *in fact* an action may have these traits, one might *believe* that it doesn't. In such a case, if one were to go through with the action, the activity (which includes your judgment about the action) would not be genuinely good.⁹⁰ In order for an activity to be genuinely good, one must undertake the action with the conviction that it is, in fact, genuinely good.⁹¹ One must “will what is good and on account of the good.”⁹²

Taken together, then, a genuinely good activity is one involving a good or neutral immediate course of action, pursued for the sake of the right sorts of good aims (always including the aim of doing what is good and right and, in some way, the aim of contributing to the good of one's community), undertaken in the appropriate manner, and with the warranted true belief that one's action is genuinely good.⁹³ If enjoyed, any activity of this sort constitutes one's happiness.

⁸⁵ See, e.g., QDV q.24 a.14 co.; ST Iallae q.107 a.1 ad 2; InSENT, lib. 4 d. 49 q.5 a.3 qc.2 ad 11.

⁸⁶ For a broader discussion of this idea and how it applies to Aquinas, see Porter (2016b), 238–256.

⁸⁷ What Aquinas calls the circumstances of an action – see, e.g., ST Iallae q.18 a.3; ST Iallae q.18 a.5 ad 4; ST Iallae q.18 a.10; ST Iallae q.20 a.1.

⁸⁸ ST Iallae q.18 a.3. ⁸⁹ ST Iallae q.18 a.3. ⁹⁰ ST Iallae q.19 a.5.

⁹¹ ST Iallae q.19 a.5. Cf. EN 2.4 1105a31–35 and InETH lib.2 l.4 n.4.

⁹² ST Iallae q.19 a.7 ad 3.

⁹³ All of these elements are parts of one single activity in this context, although some of those elements are internal and some external – see, e.g., ST Iallae q.20 a.3 co. I say “warranted,” rather than “justified” because “justified” suggests a well-worked out understanding of why an action is good. Aquinas doesn't hold this sort of requirement. Indeed, he explicitly distinguishes between knowing that something is right connaturally (through what you're drawn to as a result of some good trait

Still, even if they are enjoyed equally, not all genuinely good activities involve the same level of happiness. This is so because not all genuinely good activities are equally good – “there are some human acts that are better than others.”⁹⁴ And “since happiness consists in activity, the degree of happiness is to be taken from the degree of perfection in acting.”⁹⁵ So, all else being equal, the better the genuinely good activity is that you’re enjoying, the happier you are while so engaged. According to Aquinas, the fact that not all genuinely good activities are equally good is explained in part, as we’d suspect, by the fact that, for example, not all immediate courses of action are equally good and not all good aims are equally good.⁹⁶ But it is worth drawing attention to a further pair of more particular features of activities relevant to degrees of genuine goodness that have an important role to play in Aquinas’s treatment of happiness.

First, how good the fitting good in the world is that our activity gets us in touch with influences the level of genuine goodness found in an activity.⁹⁷ Speaking of the sorts of activities in which happiness consists, Aquinas says, for example, that “any one of these activities must be more perfect when its object is more perfect.”⁹⁸ The basic thought here is simple: some things are better than others. Beethoven’s Fifth Symphony, for example, is a better piece of music than the “Happy Birthday” song. And when our activity gets us in touch with something fitting for us that is better, then – all else being equal – our activity is better. And, as a result, when our activity gets us in touch with something that is fitting for us that is better, all else being equal, we’re happier. Our happiness, then, is often in large part about relating in the right ways to other valuable things in the world, whether works of art or nature or friends or knowledge or other worthwhile things.⁹⁹

It is by means of this principle that the gap between perfect and imperfect happiness is principally established. As Aquinas is particularly eager to point out, God in God’s essence is infinitely good, and anything

within you) and knowing that something is right through the use of reason (see, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.45 a.2 co.).

⁹⁴ SCG lib.3 c.139 n.3. See, e.g., SCG lib.3 c.139 n.1. See also, e.g., SCG lib.3 c.139 n.2.

⁹⁵ InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.4 qc.2 co. (Cf. InETH lib.10 l.9 n.14.)

⁹⁶ For the not all immediate courses of action claim, see, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.20 a.5 co. For the not all aims equal claim, see, e.g., SCG lib.3 c.138 n.7 and InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.5 a.3 qc.2 ad 11. The circumstances of one’s actions may also make an activity better or worse – see, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.18 a.11 co.

⁹⁷ InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.4 qc.2 co. See also, e.g., InSENT lib.1 d.1 q.1 a.3 qc.3 co.

⁹⁸ SCG lib.3 c.25 n.3. See also, e.g., SCG lib.3 c.35 n.3.

⁹⁹ See Porter (2016b), esp. 104–113, 238–256.

else that our activities might get us in touch with is finitely good.¹⁰⁰ And since only those in heaven are in touch with God in God's essence, it must be the case that they enjoy unparalleled and, indeed, perfect happiness – a happiness in comparison with which all other sorts of happiness are but imperfect likenesses.¹⁰¹ This principle is also one fundamental reason that Aquinas elevates the happiness of the contemplative life, which primarily involves getting in touch with important truths, over that of the active life, which primarily involves securing goods for people.¹⁰² Interestingly, this principle can also help us to explain certain widely shared judgments about well-known cases today. For example, it can help to explain why there is something lamentable from the perspective of happiness when a brilliant mathematician gives up on their work and instead contentedly counts blades of grass.¹⁰³ It can also help us to explain, for example, why ordinary people are happier in the real world than in a kind of Experience Machine, which provides them with virtual experiences designed to please them.¹⁰⁴

The second particular feature of activities worth drawing special attention to due to its place in Aquinas's treatment of happiness has to do with the character of one's relationship to the fitting good that one's activity puts one in touch with. According to Aquinas, all else being equal, the better the character of one's relationship to the fitting good in question, the better one's activity is.¹⁰⁵ To understand what this principle is getting at, an example in which two people are doing some activity together will be helpful. Take Megan and Maxine as they watch an excellent performance of Shakespeare's *Othello*. Megan, an accomplished poet and student of Shakespeare, is able to grasp the poetic genius of Shakespeare far more deeply than Maxine. As a result, although they are engaged in the same activity and that activity is directed at precisely the same thing, Megan relates to that thing in a more intimate way. As a result, Megan's activity is better than Maxine's.

Since, all else being equal, the better a genuinely good activity is the happier one is while engaged in it (and one's being better related to the

¹⁰⁰ See DeYoung, McCluskey, and Van Dyke (2009), 13–26.

¹⁰¹ That God as object or exterior end is the most fundamental cause of perfect happiness, see, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.2 qc.2 ad 2.

¹⁰² See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.3 a.5 co.; SCG lib.3 c.35 n.3; ST IaIIae q.182 a.2 co. See also, e.g., ST IaIIae q.66 a.6 ad 3. For Aquinas on contemplation, see Oliva (2012) and especially Van Nieuwenhove (2021).

¹⁰³ Rawls (1999), 379. Aquinas would likely deny that the grass counter is genuinely happy at all because, according to Aquinas, learning the truth about something that "is useless in itself" is a bad thing to do (InSENT lib.3 d.35 q.2 a.3 qc.3 co.).

¹⁰⁴ Nozick (1974), 42–43. ¹⁰⁵ See, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.2 a.4.

fitting good in question makes for a better genuinely good activity), all else being equal, the better the character of one's relationship to the fitting good that one's activity puts one in touch with, the happier one is.¹⁰⁶ As a result, engaging with something good and valuable more deeply in the context of a genuinely good activity makes a difference to how happy a person is. Returning to Megan and Maxine, even if their activities are in every other way identically good and even if they are enjoying their activities equally, Megan is happier while watching *Othello* because she relates to that fitting good more deeply. Or, to use Aquinas's dearest example, those whose intellectual grasp of God in God's essence is profounder are by that very fact happier in heaven.¹⁰⁷ So, although the residents of heaven are all engaged in precisely the same activity, they don't all do that activity equally well, and so, in part for that reason, they are not all equally happy.

2.4 The Resulting View

We have now seen that, when happiness is understood as something both attractive and genuinely good, Aquinas's account has a lot going for it. On the one hand, invoking enjoyment fundamentally serves to make happiness attractive, and it does a better job of securing that result than, for example, bodily pleasure or desire-satisfaction. On the other hand, the genuine goodness of activities fundamentally serves to make it clear why happiness itself is a good and valuable thing. What emerges is a theory that makes clear why the happy are an enviable group all around. You cannot be happy while gritting your teeth and doing good things without enjoying them. You also cannot be happy simply enjoying whatever happens to tickle your fancy. Happy people both engage in and enjoy genuinely good activities. Aquinas, then, gives us a worked-out, philosophically rich, broadly Aristotelian, exclusively activity-based account of happiness.

We can also now better appreciate what it means to say that, according to Aquinas, *engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities* is at the heart of happiness. As we have just seen, a genuinely good activity is one involving a good or neutral immediate course of action that (characteristically) gets us in touch with some fitting good. It is also an activity that is pursued for the sake of the right sorts of good aims (always including the aim of doing what is good and right and, in some way, the aim of

¹⁰⁶ See, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.4 qc.2 co.

¹⁰⁷ InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.4 qc.2 co. and InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.2 a.4 co.

contributing to the good of one's community), undertaken in the appropriate manner, and with the warranted true belief that one's action is genuinely good. How genuinely good any particular activity is depends, for example, on how good one's immediate course of action is and how good one's aims are, as well as on the fitting good that one's activity gets one in touch with and on the character of one's connection to that fitting good. On the other hand, one's enjoying such an activity involves their loving or desiring or being drawn to something presented to their rational appetite by reason as a fitting good in itself and as attained. That *something* that is enjoyed will characteristically be both the fitting good that one is in touch with *and* the very activity whereby one is in touch with that fitting good, since a genuinely good activity is also a fitting good in itself.¹⁰⁸ Or put technically, "the proximate cause of delight is an activity, but the remote [cause] is the object of the activity."¹⁰⁹ To be clear, Aquinas holds that "the good that is the proper object of delight is activity," rather than any further good the activity gets one in touch with.¹¹⁰ So it is right to put the heart of happiness in terms of enjoying *activities*, in particular, which include fitting good objects as parts, rather than simply in terms of enjoying goods out there in the world.

As we've seen, this account allows Aquinas to explain in a compelling way not only who is happy, but also who is happier than who. Explaining degrees of happiness runs through three fundamental features connected to the relevant activities. First, there is how genuinely good one's enjoyable activity is. Second, there is how much one is enjoying that genuinely good activity. Finally, there is the duration of one's activity. This last fundamental feature should come as no surprise, although it has not been explicitly mentioned to this point. After all, all else being equal, holding on to a good thing is itself a good thing, which comes through since, as Aquinas points out, "everyone naturally desires . . . to remain in the good that they have."¹¹¹ As applied to happiness itself, since happiness is an activity and human activities are extended in time, all else being equal, one is happier the longer one continues enjoying a genuinely good activity.¹¹²

¹⁰⁸ ST IaIIae q.31 a.5 co.; ST IaIIae q.32 a.1 co.; InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.2 co.; InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.5 qc.4 co.; ST IaIIae q.180 a.7 co.

¹⁰⁹ InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.5 qc.4 co. ¹¹⁰ InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.2 co.

¹¹¹ InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.1 qc.4 co. See also, e.g., SCG lib.3 c.29 n.7; ST IaIIae q.5 a.3 co.

¹¹² That someone can enjoy something longer than another person, see, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.3 a.1 qc.3 ad 2. This is one reason perfect happiness is best – see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.3 a.2 ad 4 (Celano (1987), 222, and López (2012), 40–41).

Notice that happiness, as Aquinas understands it, is binary in one sense and a matter of degree in another. It is binary in the sense that each and every person either is happy at a given point in time or they are not. There is always a “Yes” or “No” answer to the question, “Is that person happy?” The answer is “Yes” when the person is engaged in and enjoying a genuinely good activity. The answer is “No” when the person is not engaged in and enjoying a genuinely good activity. That is the cutoff point below which no one counts as happy. Still, as Aquinas understands it, happiness comes in degrees above this cutoff point. This is so because, for the reasons just mentioned, some people engaged in and enjoying genuinely good activities are happier than others. As we will see in subsequent chapters, this is true when it comes to natural imperfect happiness, graced imperfect happiness, and even perfect happiness. Indeed, it will turn out that no matter the degree of happiness that a person enjoys, in principle, they could always be happier – even in heaven.

2.5 Conclusion

In this chapter, I have explained and begun to argue for the Enjoying Good Activities reading of the heart of happiness in Aquinas, which is itself a version of Restrictive Perfectionism about happiness. On this reading, only a small subset of an agent’s perfections constitutes their happiness. In particular, one’s happiness in every case is constituted exclusively by one’s *activities*, when those activities are both genuinely good and enjoyed. What unifies the various kinds of happiness that Aquinas identifies and thereby serves as the heart of happiness in Aquinas is an underlying structure found in all and only those activities in which happiness consists. That structure includes, on the one hand, engagement-in-a-genuinely-good-activity and, on the other, enjoyment. It should now be clear what these claims amount to and, to some extent, why Aquinas’s distinctive form of Aristotelianism about happiness is interesting and promising philosophically.

I hope that this chapter has elicited the desire to do the hard work of establishing this reading on a more solid textual and historical basis. Establishing it on such a basis requires grappling in a deep way with each kind of happiness that Aquinas identifies. This is so because the best evidence for any interpretation concerning the heart of happiness will be that interpretation’s ability to capture clearly and consistently what makes each and every kind of happiness that Aquinas identifies relevantly similar. And so in the following three chapters I delve deeply into Aquinas’s discussions of perfect happiness, natural imperfect happiness, and graced

imperfect happiness, respectively, in order to establish and defend the Enjoying Good Activities reading by appeal to a wider range of textual and contextual elements. In so doing, I explore in greater detail both how Aquinas understands the heart of happiness laid out in this chapter and how he puts that understanding to varied and effective use in discussing everything from the most meager happiness available on earth to the highest reaches of heavenly happiness – the sort of happiness to which I now turn.